

you to the ground, crushing bones with sheer momentum and knocking the weapon from your hand. The last thing you hear is the whine of the WildCat's petrol engines, the clippity clop of its "hooves" on the ground.

This is the WildCat, well, the scary version anyway. Developed by, you guessed it, Boston Dynamics, the WildCat is part of a new generation of quadrupedal robots that are capable of a surprising turnover of speed. The current, untethered model can only manage 25kph, but DARPA and Boston Dynamics have already developed a tethered variant capable of running at almost 45kph and the plan is to achieve a top speed of 75kph in the next few years. Why? Because they can.

PEPPER

Physically, we won't be a match for robots, but what about emotionally? Pepper, is a robot that is designed with only one purpose in mind and that is to communicate with humans. It doesn't actually do anything else.

Pepper will read your emotional state and respond appropriately and it does this by observing your face, body language and the words that you use. The more time this 'bot spends with you, the more it will learn about you, eventually learning that, say, your favourite song will cheer you up when you're sad. Pepper will be the emotional companion that you will eventually learn to depend on, it hopes to be in every home, every school and every hospital and provide a degree of empathy that was never before believed to be possible (Does Pepper understand sarcasm?).

For those of you with minds in the gutters, if you purchase Pepper, you're contractually obliged to, ahem, avoid inappropriate, umm, advances. It is a highly sensitive 'bot after all.

ROOMBA

An unusual entry in this list, and one that as Indians, we're not too familiar with, except maybe from watching cats vroom around on them. Roomba is a robotic vacuum cleaner. It's one of the first robots to be almost universally accepted into our lives. On the surface, there's nothing really special about Roomba. It's a disc shaped vacuum cleaner that will go about the house autonomously sucking up dirt, charging itself when needed and seamlessly adapting to your furniture and its surroundings.

The Roomba is representative of a vision of a robotic future that we would actually enjoy. Robots that integrate seamlessly into our lives, work tirelessly and perform their function effectively, but with discretion and determination.

BB-8 BY SPHERO

This here bot is a toy, but a toy unlike any other. For those who've never seen it, check out <http://dgit.in/BotBB8>. The toy itself is nothing more than a remote controlled car of sorts, but paired with your phone, it comes alive, seemingly intelligent, responding to voice commands, drawing intricate patterns and even transmitting messages.

BB-8 is going to be something special because it will do what Roomba did, introduce kids to the world of robots, opening the door to a whole range of robotic pets, toys and a new generation of child. Not many of you will remember Aibo, a robot dog that garnered quite a bit of attention in the early 2000s, but that was a bot a bit too ahead of its time. BB-8 will do what Aibo couldn't because it's small, relatively cheap and is, potentially, infinitely upgradeable (it's really powered by an app after all).



HitchBOT, loved everywhere but Philly!

HITCHBOT

This last bot is the silliest excuse for a robot that we've seen yet, but, well, it's somehow caught the attention of a select populace and it will be a shame to leave it out of this list. To those of you who don't know, hitchBOT is a dust bin with an LCD display, a GPS tracker, a bunch of solar panels and ornamental arms and legs.

The researchers who created hitchBOT wanted him to travel the world and to that end, took him outside and left him on the street, thumb pointed skywards. What happened next was

truly astounding. People picked up this hitch-hiking "robot" and took him all over Canada (a distance of approximately 10,000km), then Germany, the Netherlands and then finally landing up in USA, where it finally met its "demise" in Philadelphia at the hands of a vandal.

hitchBOT is not intelligent by any possible interpretation of the word, it's not capable of anything except showing smiley faces on its LCD and responding to certain audio cues and yet, people loved it. They took it on a world tour, pampered it, and expressed great outrage at the vandal responsible for its demise.

If all it takes for a robot to enter our lives and hearts is a smiley face and a few random words, we're already doomed. Our anthropomorphism may have gone just a little bit too far in this case. But then again, maybe not. Soldiers have been known to fall in love with their robots, going so far as to hold funerals for their fallen "comrades", and we can be fairly certain that it won't be long before Siri has a long list of lovelorn humans at her beck and call.

ROXXXY

We're entering into "Parental Advisory" territory here, so if you're a kid, stop reading NOW!

Yours for \$7,000, Roxxy is a sex robot. Note, we used the word "bot", not doll. Created by True Companion, Roxxy is an AI controlled sex robot that will "respond" to you in as natural a manner as possible. She will "have discussions with you, talk to you, feel your touch and respond accordingly." Douglas Hines, creator of Roxxy says that "Roxxy provides physical and sexual pleasure, and also social interaction and engagement. It's customising technology to provide a perfect partner — she's not meant to replace a real partner but is instead meant as a supplement." (Read the full interview at <http://dgit.in/xxbotxx>).

There are arguments on both sides, for and against such bots, with one side defending their therapeutic abilities, and the other decrying the objectification of women that the robot represents — there's a male bot called Rocky for those who feel that.

Many are calling for their ban, or a detailed study on their impact on human-human relationships. However, once these bots are popular, there will be nothing that we can do to stop their spread. **[1]**